

Literature 1860-1945

This course aims to further develop students' knowledge and critical understanding of world anglophone literature in the timeframe 1860-1945 through several narrative themes. This timeframe is a period of emergence and competition; as new technological worlds are born, the New World comes to the fore as the dominant power, but at whose exclusion? Pitching an oscillatory dialogue between Europe and America this course will trace the genealogies of sexuality, economics and psychoanalysis that come to dominate contemporary thought.

For some weeks the reading list is split into primary and secondary reading. Everybody should complete the primary reading as this is the only basis for a profitable discussion. In the week of your presentation, I would recommend reading the second work as well and attempting to relate the two to one another. Some of the weeks are highly theoretical. In these cases, I would prefer that you struggle through the texts and remain baffled than to give up reading them; we will be able to discuss them in class and, hopefully, they will make more sense in this context.

Assessment

The course will be assessed through two components: a presentation [20%] and a 4000 word essay [80%]. The presentation will be recorded in class and form part of an ongoing web project to document the texts we have studied over the course of the term.

Week 1: The Birth of Modernity

Opening with a theoretical work, we will use this session to question what we understand by "Modernity"

Primary Reading

Charles Baudelaire, "The Painter of Modern Life" [1863]

Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Birth of Tragedy* [1872]

Secondary Reading

Matei Calinescu, *Five Faces of Modernity* [1987], Chapter 1

Week 2: "All That Is the Case": The New World

As the nineteenth century drew to a close, an era of unbounded scientific and logical positivism was entered. In this week we will discuss the period from 1895 to 1921 by one work of literature and one of philosophy.

Primary Reading

H.G. Wells, *The Time Machine* [1895]

Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* [1921], Propositions 1.*, 4.*, 5.* and 7.*.

Secondary Reading

William Morris, *News From Nowhere* [1890]

Week 3: "A Profitable Darkness": Slavery and American Literature

Considering the technical progress in this era, it soon emerges as inseparable from the situation in the United States, which revolves around slavery. This week will look at two very different works by American authors and question the conservative and progressive elements in each.

Primary Reading

Herman Melville, "Benito Cereno" [1855]

Mark Twain, *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* [1884]

Secondary Reading

Harriet Beecher-Stowe, *Uncle Tom's Cabin* [1852]

Frederick Douglass, *A Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave* [1845]

Week 4: Fin de Siècle Feminism

This week, expanded upon in the next, will begin to look at female writing and sexuality in a period considered, traditionally, extremely conservative.

Primary Reading

Theodor Dreiser, *Sister Carrie* [1900]

Charlotte Perkins Gilman, "The Yellow Wallpaper" [1892]

Secondary Reading

Charlotte Perkins Gilman, *Herland* [1915]

Week 5: We Other Victorians

This week will focus upon, and trouble the concept of, an "emergence" of sexuality in a period usually defined as sexually repressive. Using the frame of Michel Foucault's *The History of Sexuality* as a revision of this hypothesis, we will explore representations of feminism and female sexual desire in Chopin's *The Awakening*.

Primary Reading

Michel Foucault, *The History of Sexuality: Part I* [1976]

Kate Chopin, *The Awakening* [1899]

Week 6: Modernism

This week will serve as a theoretical underpinning for further work on the emergent period of "Modernism" looking at the canonical works of Nietzsche and Mann as instigating an era of increasing relativistic thought.

Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Genealogy of Morals* [1887]

Thomas Mann, *Death in Venice* [1917]

T.S. Eliot, "Tradition and the Individual Talent"

Week 7: "Armageddonite Filth": World War I and Modern Memory

This week, along with the next, will examine the poetry and prose of World War I in light of a cultural event that transformed the contemporary landscape. The importance of the theoretical reading (Fussell) this week cannot be underplayed.

Paul Fussell, *The Great War and Modern Memory* [1975], Chapter 1

John McCrae, "In Flanders Fields" [1915]

Siegfried Sasson, "Suicide in the Trenches" [1918]

Wilfred Owen, "Maundy Thursday" [1915]

Wilfred Owen, "Has Your Soul Sipped?" [1917]

Week 8: “One of the triumphs of civilization”: World War I, Woolf and the Psyche

In this continuation of the literature of and pertaining to World War I we will consider two of Woolf's works in relation to another significant theorist of the twentieth century: Sigmund Freud.

Sigmund Freud, “Thoughts for the Time on War and Death” [1915]

Virginia Woolf, *Mrs Dalloway* [1925]

Virginia Woolf, *Between the Acts* [1941]

Week 9: Economies of Scale

Moving away from the war and on towards American consumer culture, this week will juxtapose the culture of conspicuous consumption against Marx's work which was so shaping for economic thought. In economic readings of *Gatsby*, how much account should be taken of the sexual trading in the novel?

Karl Marx, *The Communist Manifesto* [1848], Part I

F. Scott Fitzgerald, *The Great Gatsby* [1925]

Week 10: Modernity and Marginalization

Examining the flip side of week nine's conspicuous consumption, this week will query the economic flip side of exploitation, up to seventy years after the Civil War.

Joseph Conrad, *Heart of Darkness* [1899]

Nella Larsen, *Passing* [1929]

Secondary Reading

Simone de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex* [1952], Introduction

Week 11: “it is rare that the feeling of absurdity is not followed by the feeling of necessity”: The Second Act

This week will explore the literature of “absurdity” in relation to bureaucratization and the impending second world war through the writings of Kafka and Beckett. We will also examine the role of high art in society in the wake of the calamitous social events of this period.

Primary Reading:

Franz Kafka, *The Trial* [1925]

Samuel Beckett, *Watt* [1943]

Secondary Reading:

Walter Benjamin, “The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction” in *Illuminations*

Adorno and Horkheimer, “The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception”, in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*

Week 12: “If This is a Man”: Retrospectives

This final week will look at para-temporal texts that look back upon World War II with hindsight. Here we will conclude with questions on the nature of historical fiction and the ways in which the course has been shaped by our own contemporary understanding.

Primary Reading

Joseph Heller, *Catch-22* [1961]

Kurt Vonnegut, *Slaughterhouse-Five* [1969]

Secondary Reading

Primo Levi, *If This is a Man* [1958]

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